

Reading the Search Term Report — Quick Guide

How to turn a raw Search Term Report into winners to scale and bleeders to cut.

What the Search Term Report Is

The Search Term Report (STR) shows the actual customer search terms that triggered your ads — as opposed to the keywords/targets you bid on. For Broad and Phrase match especially, the customer's real search can differ a lot from your target keyword. The STR is where you find both new keyword opportunities and wasted spend.

Columns You'll See

Column	Meaning
Customer Search Term	What the shopper actually typed
Targeting	The keyword/target your ad was bidding on that matched this search
Match Type	Broad, Phrase, Exact, or Auto
Impressions / Clicks	How often the ad was shown / clicked for this search term
Spend	Total cost attributed to this search term
Sales / Orders	Attributed sales and order count from this search term (7- or 14-day window depending on category)

Spotting a Winner

- Multiple orders (2+) at or under the account's target ACOS.
- A search term you weren't directly bidding on — a real discovery.
- Consistent performance over more than a few clicks (don't call a winner off 1 lucky order).
- **Action:** add it as a new Exact-match keyword in its own ad group so you can control its bid precisely.

Spotting a Bleeder

- Zero orders with spend well past what a single conversion would cost you (a good rule of thumb: 2–3x your average cost-per-order for the account).
- Zero orders with a high click count — the term gets traffic but never converts, which usually means relevance mismatch, not bad luck.
- **Action:** add it as a negative exact keyword at the campaign or ad group level so it stops matching, without blocking the broader keyword it came from.

A Word on Sample Size

Don't act on 1–2 clicks either way. A term with 3 clicks and 0 orders isn't proven to be a bleeder — it just hasn't had enough chances yet. The STR Winner/Bleeder Scanner in this download center uses a minimum-spend and minimum-click threshold before it will flag something as a Bleeder, for exactly this reason.

Common Mistakes

- 1 Negating a keyword that's also your best-converting Exact target elsewhere — always check where a term is already working before you block it.
- 2 Judging ACOS on a single order in a low-volume account; look at the account's average order value and time window first.
- 3 Forgetting to check date range — a term that looks dead over 24 hours may be fine over 30 days.

Pair this guide with the STR Winner/Bleeder Scanner (automation tools) to turn this process into a repeatable weekly routine.

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